Go to Mary:
Our Lady of the Holy Rosary

A Study of Sacred Art



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The Importance of Family Prayer

Father Patrick Peyton preached these profound words from his heart, “The first sentence of our Holy Rosary is worth all the gold of the Earth, and this is what it is and what I heard as a little child: ‘I believe in God.’" When it came to teaching on the Rosary and spreading the message about the importance of family prayer many said Father Peyton had a single-minded focus.

Family prayer, especially the Rosary, is a solid foundation to build a faithful family—a family on the Rock of faith, alongside Mary. We can go to Mary, a link between heaven and earth in our every need. The Rosary is that chain linking the heavenly kingdom with our earthly one. As Father Peyton, himself said, "The Rosary is a chain that binds the family together."

October is the Month of the Rosary. This is a perfect time to strengthen prayer in your home by committing to the pray the Rosary together or introduce this beautiful, powerful prayer to your family. Whether you've been praying for years or are just learning of this special devotion, the Blessed Mother, wishes to walk alongside you and your family, especially when you pray the Rosary.

A Little History

Venerable Patrick Peyton began his ministry in 1942 with the goal of building family unity through daily prayer of the Rosary. Inspired by his own father who had a deep appreciation for family prayer, praying the Rosary became the foundation for the life of Father Peyton (1909-92).

We at Family Rosary are ever so grateful Father Peyton’s family instilled in him the importance of family prayer. Now it can be part of your family’s tradition so you can fulfill Father Peyton’s vision, “The Family That Prays Together Stays Together.”

Family Rosary
HOLY CROSS
FAMILY MINISTRIES

The family that prays together stays together

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Introduction

Saint John Paul II opens his encyclical, "Rosarium Virginis Mariae," with these profound words,

"The Rosary of the Virgin Mary, which gradually took form in the second millennium under the guidance of the Spirit of God, is a prayer loved by countless Saints and encouraged by the Magisterium."

The admiration for Our Lady of the Rosary, the Christ child, and the Rosary itself has become the inspiration for numerous works of sacred art. This eBook explores four exquisite yet vastly different depictions of these subjects with the design to not only educate but also offer a unique way to enter into prayer.

We invite you, especially as a family, to spend time not only familiarizing yourself with the art by enjoying the informative text but also engaging in studying the art itself. Perhaps you are familiar with Lectio Divina (divine reading), a method for contemplating and praying with the Scriptures. Visio Divina, which translates to "divine seeing," uses visual elements instead of words to help you explore the details of the art as a means to enter into prayer.

Prayerfully focusing on the details and intricacies of the art piece, the Holy Spirit can draw you to a deeper understanding of the tender relationship between the Blessed Mother, her Son, and the prayer she herself gave to us, the Rosary.

Art of Our Lady of the Holy Rosary

Study, Reflection, and Prayer through Sacred Art

1. *Madonna of the Sweet Pea, Unknown artist, 1410, Germany.*
2. *Virgin and Child with Infant St. John the Baptist, Bernard van Orley, 1541, Belgium.*
3. *Madonna and the Rosary, Bartolomeo Esteban Murillo, c. 1650, Spain.*
4. *Our Lady of the Rosary with St. Dominic and St. Rose of Lima, Unknown Artist, 16th c, Peru.*









The family that prays together stays together



1. Madonna of the Sweet Pea, Unknown artist, 1410, Germany.

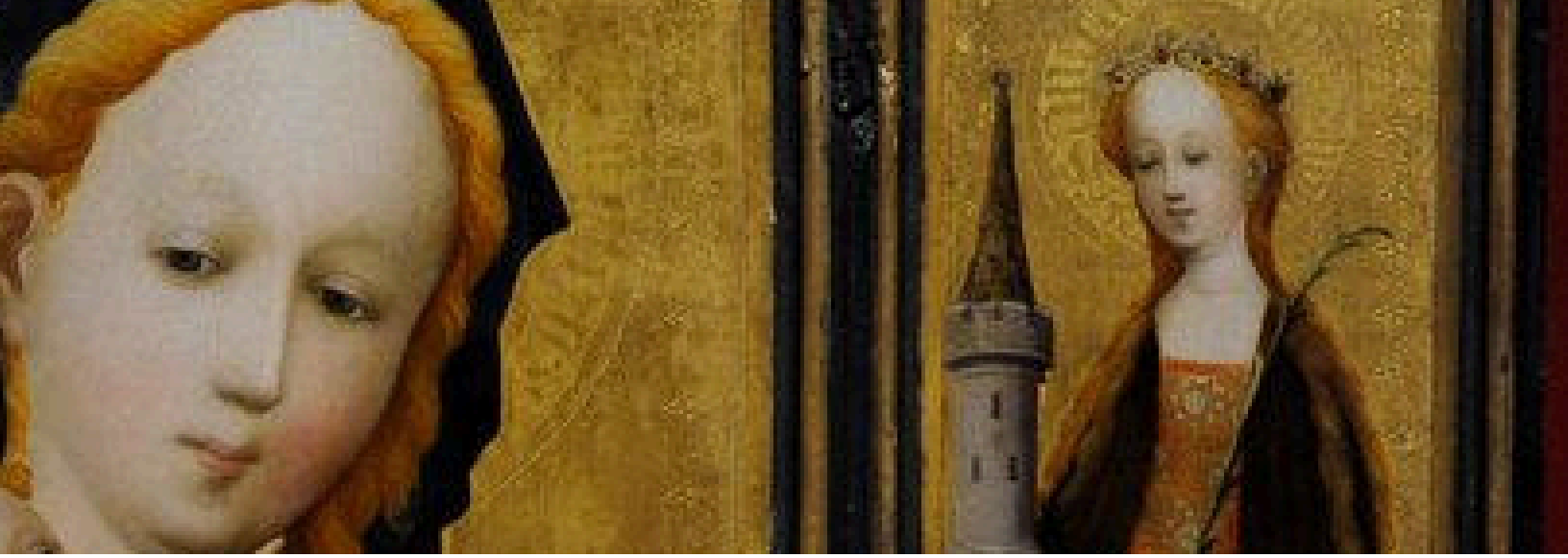
This artwork is known as a triptych, which has a long tradition in Christian art. A triptych refers to the fact that there are three panels. Usually, the two side panels are thinner than the center panel and can be closed like window shutters. Larger triptychs for altarpieces would also have an image on the outside of the panels; the inner image was only revealed during Sunday Mass and on major holidays. The small size of this triptych means it was 'portable' and the owner took it with him while traveling – or even on pilgrimage.

This triptych centers around a Madonna and Child. Mary holds a Sweet Pea in her hand, and the Christ child holds prayer beads. The Sweet Pea is a Marian flower and tradition tells that the Sweet Pea grew in the footsteps of Mary, leaving a pleasant aroma.

The Christ Child holds an early version of the Rosary – a simple strand of beads with a large medallion. The official Rosary as we know it today was not institutionalized by the Church until 1569. But this artwork proves that the Rosary was already a popular prayer among Christians over 150 years earlier.

The Christ child cradles his mother's face, an affectionate gesture showing their close bond. It is also a message from Christ, who tells us that by following Mary, we also follow Him.

The side panels of the triptych contain two female saints (left), who were most likely selected by the owner. St. Catherine of Alexandria is on the left, and St. Barbara is on the right. St. Catherine is identified by her crown, as she was born into royalty. By her side are the instruments of her passion: a sword, and a wheel.



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On the right is St. Barbara, who is less well known today. She holds the palm leaf of martyrdom, as well as a tower – a symbol of her suffering. Locked in a tower by her pagan father, St. Barbara refused to marry and dedicated her life to Christ. Tortured for her faith, St. Barbara was miraculously healed every morning. Both female saints have long, loose hair signifying that they were virgins upon their death. The gold background evokes Heaven, where Mary and the saints now watch over us.



Unknown artist
Madonna of the Sweet Pea
1410, Germany



2. Virgin and Child with Infant St. John the Baptist , Bernard van Orley, 1541, Belgium.

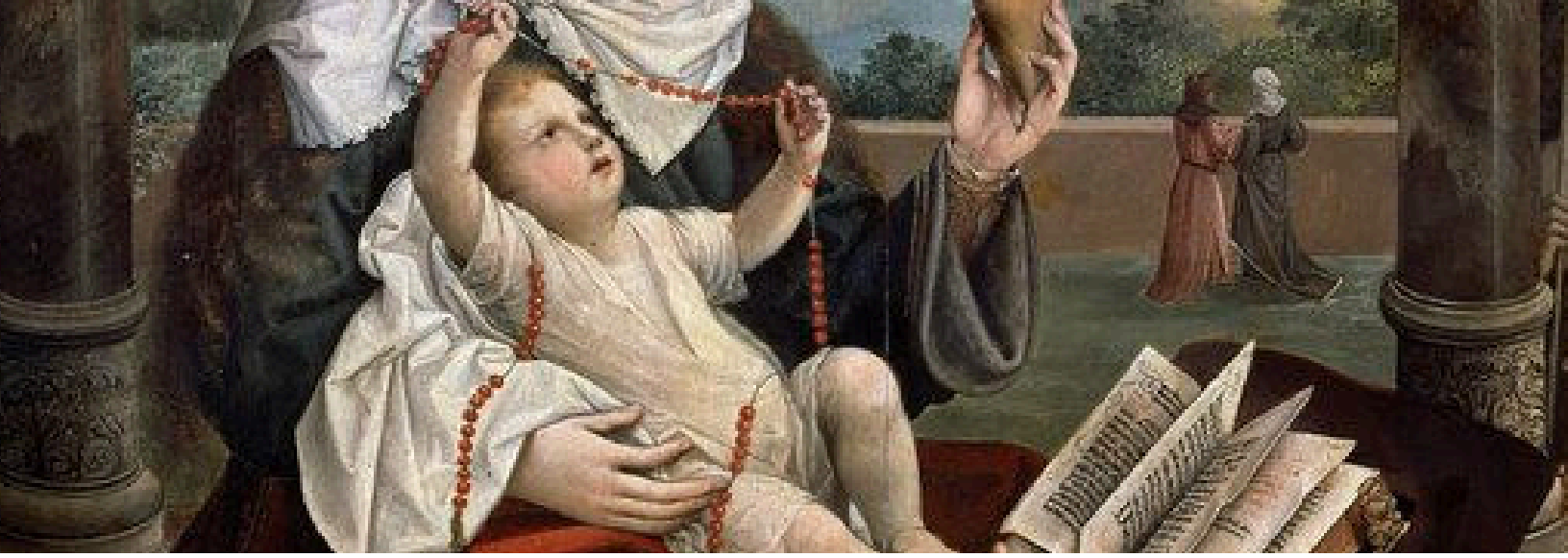
Madonna and Child are seated in a renaissance-style balcony looking out into a beautiful landscape. This is a reference to Mary's immaculate conception — she is untouched by sin and therefore enclosed from the outside world. In Mary's hand is a pear, a symbol of her role as the New Eve — and the beautiful landscape behind her is therefore the new Eden.

As Pope Pius IX proclaimed in 1854:

"The most Blessed Virgin Mary was, from the first moment of her conception, by a singular grace and privilege of almighty God and by virtue of the merits of Jesus Christ, Saviour of the human race, preserved immune from all stain of original sin."

Strolling casually in the background are a couple in contemporary Belgian clothing. Their presence tells us that Mary is not simply a historical figure but that she is always with us.

St. John Paul II, in his encyclical, "Rosarium Virginis Mariae," quotes from Blessed Bartolo Longo who illustrates this beautifully: "Just as two friends, frequently in each other's company, tend to develop similar habits, so too, by holding familiar converse with Jesus and the Blessed Virgin, by meditating on the mysteries of the Rosary and by living the same life in Holy Communion, we can become, to the extent of our lowliness, similar to them and can learn from these supreme models a life of humility, poverty, hiddenness, patience and perfection."



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The Christ child sits in Mary's lap playing with red prayer beads. At the time, it was common for Rosary beads to be color-coded for the Mysteries. In this case, the red beads are a symbol of the Sorrowful Mysteries and Christ's Passion. (Blue represented the Glorious Mysteries, while Green represented Joyful). Specifically, Christ is playing with red coral beads.

Coral beads and amulets were common gift for babies in the Renaissance because they were considered talismans of protection. Coral is mentioned several times in Scripture and considered equal to gems in terms of worth. A living plant, coral was also associated with Christ in that it represented rebirth and renewal -- the soft membrane was also good for teething infants. Similar Renaissance paintings with the Christ child or young children, feature similar red prayer beads.

In the shadow to the right is a young St. John the Baptist, identified by his reed cross and animal-skin cloth. He points towards the Christ child and the opened Scriptures, reminding us that Christ's coming was foretold, and that He is the Lamb of God.



Bernard van Orley
Virgin and Child with Infant St. John the Baptist
1541, Belgium



3. Madonna and the Rosary, Bartolomeo Esteban Murillo, c. 1650, Spain.

This Madonna and Child is a common example of artwork painted during the 17th century, after the Protestant Reformation had taken over much of Northern Europe. The Church depended heavily on artists to persuade people away from the new Protestant faith. Artwork focused on Catholic dogma: specifically, the mysteries of the faith, the Virgin Mary, as well as the lives of the Saints. Artwork in countries that remained Catholic, such as Spain and Italy, celebrated the genuine relationship between Mother and Child as an example of the strong bond between Catholics and God.

King Philip II of Spain was especially devout and commissioned religious art that would spiritually enrich and inspire his people. Artists, like Bartolomeo Esteban Murillo, created the Spanish Baroque style of art, which was unique from the rest of Europe. Murillo was especially celebrated for his ability to create artistically 'simple' artworks that instead relied heavily on drama to inspire piety. Baroque art abandoned backgrounds and other miscellaneous details to focus on true veneration of Christ. In this painting, the Madonna and Child are illuminated with the light of God; they are all that matters.

At the time Protestants criticized the Rosary as a means for worshipping Mary above Christ, but in this painting, we see the truth of the Rosary. The Rosary is a bond between the Virgin and her Son, which is a bond she longs for all people to have with her Son. The Rosary is growing in knowledge and understanding of Christ, guided by the Virgin Mary. Like the beads themselves, she is a companion for our prayers.

Finally, and perhaps most importantly, we see a Mary and Christ child who look like us. Previous Renaissance art celebrated the regality and heavenly might of Christ as King. But here, Mary is not enthroned in riches as Queen of Heaven, instead she resembles someone you might have seen in your daily life in the 17th century. Christ too is transformed into an adorable toddler. Depicting the Christ child as a human child with baby fat and a curious gaze does not take away from the truth that He is King of Kings.



Bartolomeo Esteban Murillo
Madonna and the Rosary
c. 1650, Spain



4. Our Lady of the Rosary with St. Dominic and St. Rose of Lima, Unknown Artist, 16th c, Peru.

St. Dominic and St. Rose of Lima pray before a shrine dedicated to Our Lady and the Christ child, a large Rosary held between them. This painting comes from the New World, painted in Peru during the Spanish colonial period. Religious men and women of the Dominican Order, such as St. Rose, were influential in the evangelization of the Peruvian people as well as other South American colonies.

St. Dominic wears the colors of his order, black and white, and in his hand are white lilies — a symbol of purity and of the Annunciation. According to tradition St. Dominic was given the Rosary by Mary so that he would educate mankind in the prayer and promised his apostolic efforts would be blessed if he did. Beside St. Dominic is St. Rose of Lima, the first American saint canonized by the Catholic Church.

St. Rose of Lima (born Isabel Flores de Olivia) was born to a Spanish father, Gaspar Flores, and María de Oliva y Herrera (b. 1560), a criolla native of Lima. She became devout at a young age and wished to enter religious life, against her father's wishes. She eventually became a member of the Third Order of St. Dominic, living in the world, outside the conventual life of vowed religious. On her head is a crown of roses. This is a reference to her name but also that she wore a penitential silver crown of thorns in imitation of Christ. St. Rose of Lima also holds a palm leaf in her hand, but it does not refer to her martyrdom. Instead, it is another symbol her emulation of Christ, as he carried the palm leaf into Jerusalem.

While we do not know the exact date this painting was made, we do have some clues. We know that St. Rose of Lima was beatified by the Church in 1667. Her sainthood was celebrated throughout Peru, and this is probably one of many paintings created for her veneration at this time.



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This style of art is specific to the region of Peru, as it is a mixture of Western baroque themes and traditional Peruvian themes – this became known as the Cuzco School, as it started in the city of Cuzco in the 16th century. Features of the Cuzco school include western baroque themes but added bright colors and flora native to Peru. St. Rose of Lima is the patroness of flowers and embroidery, both of which are used to honor Mary and Jesus depicted in this image.

The enormous gowns worn by Mary and the Christ Child are depicted in detail – another feature of the Cuzco school. The flat appearance of the clothing is on purpose; it does not need to look like normal clothing. There are gold embroidery, pearls, and lace, as well as jewels. Clearly, these are outfits meant only for the King of Kings and his mother, the Queen of Heaven.

Both saints hold black Rosaries, part of the habits of the Dominican order, but they also offer their Rosaries in service to Mary, promising to spread devotion to her throughout the colonized New World.



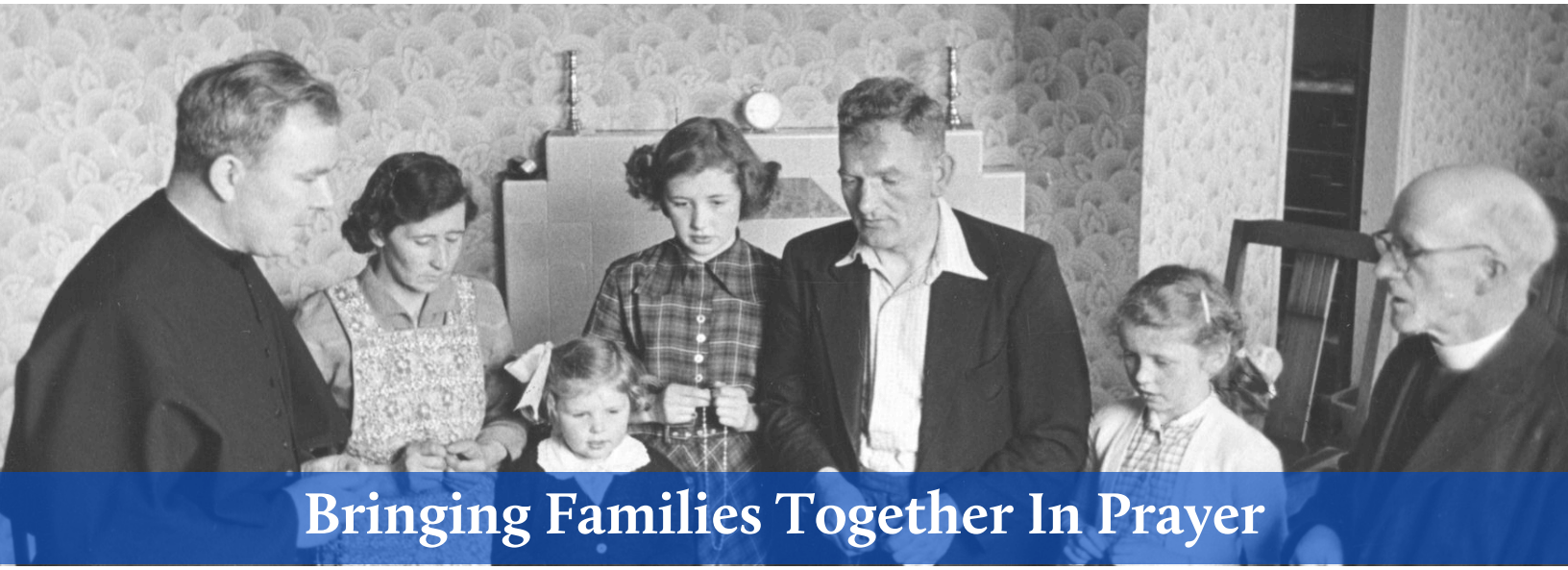
Unknown Artist
Our Lady of the Rosary with St. Dominic and St. Rose of Lima
16th c, Peru

This October, the Month of the Rosary:
"Go to Mary: A Link Between Heaven and Earth."
Grow in the faith with your family.

For a wealth of daily prayer resources for you and your family, join our Global Prayer Campaign filled with videos, eBooks, podcasts, prayers, reflections, and social posts—everything you need for a rich, faith-filled month.

Find all of your family prayer resources at FamilyRosary.org.

Keep an eye on:
Family Rosary @ familyrosary.org
Catholic Mom @ catholicmom.com
Museum of Family Prayer @ museumoffamilyprayer.com
and on our Facebook, Instagram, and Twitter sites too!
#FamilyPrayer #FamilyRosary #PraytheRosary #GoToMary



Bringing Families Together In Prayer

We hope the time you've spent reflecting with this material has been enriching. Continue to pray with your family every day, wherever you are.

For additional online resources for family prayer including additional e-books and the mobile Rosary App, please visit our website at FamilyRosary.org.

This e-book and all our resources represent a culmination of Father Peyton's passion for family unity through prayer. We hope our services will enhance your family's prayer life particularly remembering Father Peyton's famous words, "The family that prays together stays together."